

The man who kept turning up

For nearly two decades, **Ajinkya Rahane** kept arriving early, working quietly and waiting patiently for the next chance. Even when the waiting became the story.

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If Ajinkya Rahane had one obsession, it wasn't batting. It was punctuality, particularly for training.

Ask those who travelled with him on Mumbai's local trains as a teenager, or teammates who shared dressing rooms with him

years later, and they will tell you the same thing. Reporting on time was a habit for their beloved 'Aju'.

Early in his career, he knew that missing a train meant missing practice. Somewhere between Dombivli and Churchgate, via Dadar, punctuality became part of his personality.

That perhaps explains why Rahul Dravid enjoyed working with him at Rajasthan Royals.

Jaipur afternoons could be unforgiving. Once training ended, most players wanted to retreat to the cool corners of a cafe. But Rahane and Dravid would often stay back at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium, among the first to arrive and the last to leave. Sometimes it was an extended batting session, sometimes just long conversations about the game. Rahane has often acknowledged how much he learnt from Dravid during those years.

Years later, there was an irony neither of them could have imagined. By the time Dravid became India's head coach in 2021, Rahane had almost disappeared from the Test side. The mentor who had shaped much of his professional outlook was now leading an Indian team that had

largely moved on from him.

Rahane never complained. But he did admit that the silence was difficult to understand.

"After playing so much of cricket, when experienced players like me were dropped, I got a sense that there's something different. I feel an experienced player like me should get more chances when he makes a comeback. But there was no communication," he had told *Sportstar*.

That summed up Rahane better than any innings ever could. He was never the loudest voice in the room, never one to campaign for himself or seek public sympathy. He simply wanted clarity. Throughout his career, he believed honesty deserved honesty in return.

Rahane often spoke about his upbringing without making much of it. The local trains, the middle-class neighbourhood, the friends he grew up with and the coaches who drilled discipline into him stayed with him. Even after captaining India, he remained, at heart, a Mumbai cricketer.

Inside the Mumbai dressing room, Rahane could be almost old-fashioned.

For him, the cap was special.

During one Ranji Trophy season, three winters back, a former Mumbai captain walked into the dressing room to address the players. A few youngsters weren't particularly keen on sitting through it after a long day. Rahane, then leading the side, stepped in immediately. There wasn't much discussion. He politely told them to get into the dressing room.

The message was clear: If

someone has worn that cap before you, you listen to them.

That approach occasionally made him seem rigid to younger players. Rahane didn't mind. He wasn't interested in being the popular senior. He was interested in preserving a culture he had inherited.

It wasn't just about discipline. It was about gratitude. Rahane belonged to a generation of Mumbai cricketers that believed the dressing room was bigger than the individual. Seniors were respected, traditions were protected and every cap carried the weight of those who had worn it before. Those values shaped him as much as the countless hours in the nets.

Against the grain

His leadership reflected the same philosophy.

In an era when captains were often defined by animated huddles and grand speeches, Rahane preferred quiet conversations. He wasn't theatrical. Yet he won four of the six Tests in which he captained India, while two were drawn. He rarely sought the spotlight. But even then, teammates repeatedly spoke about the calm he brought to the dressing room. He absorbed pressure rather than transferring it to those around him.

Even after his last Test appearance in 2023, he never stopped believing another opportunity would come.

"The dream is to still play for India. I just want to be in the moment, learn from my mistakes and whenever an opportunity comes, just grab it," he had said. Of course, there was disappointment, especially when